

(Almost) No theory, Just a Task

A Regime Theory of Joy: The Minimal Z-reduction Task

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Z

Z is evaluative load: the sense that an experience must be assessed, evaluated, or converted into a next action.

High Z directs us toward more instrumental regimes, where attention is organized around goals. When Z falls, perception and action become less tightly coupled, and something can matter without requiring a response. More pleasant regimes become easier to enter.

In early childhood, fewer causal links are learned: the next action often remains undetermined. Ease, the regime supporting joy, is the baseline. Children probably barely notice it, and therefore certainly never report it.

What also changes in adulthood is that the next action is pressing forward. At school, too, a bell meant preparing for what came next. But there were genuine breaks: periods in which nothing further could be done, even if one wanted to do something. That was where intense joy could exist. The regime supporting joy and other permissive features is erased by the constant certainty that another precise action must follow.

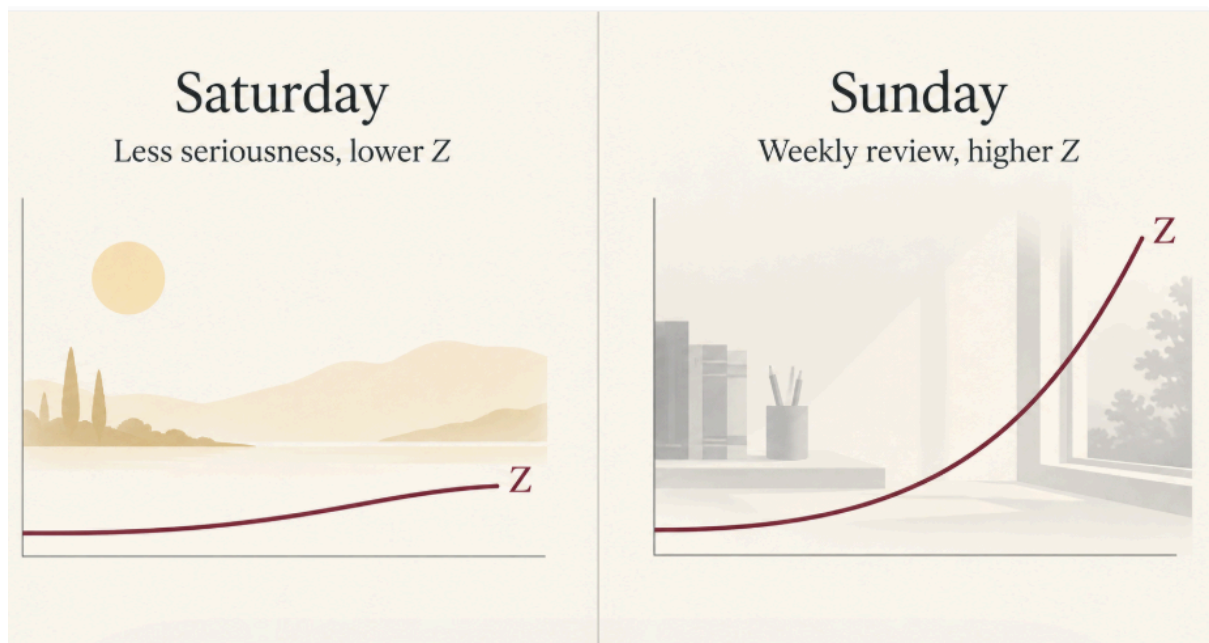
Many behaviours increase Z, such as indulging in political news. But the relation is reciprocal: once Z is elevated, it also increases the pull toward them.

Z is **experienced** as a sense of seriousness.

Z = Seriousness

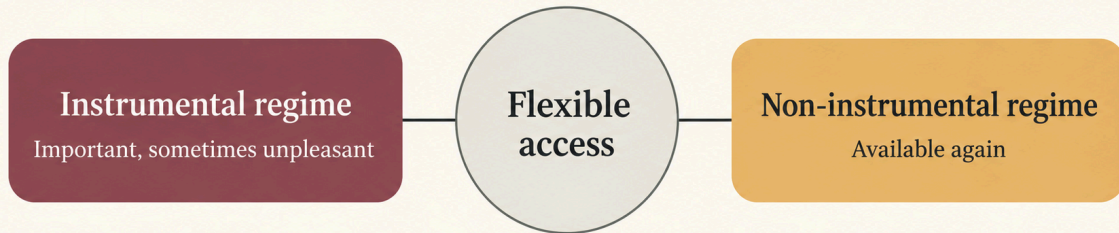
The felt load of evaluation, consequence, and next-action pressure.

When Saturday arrives, the weekend begins and life feels less serious. Z falls, making entry into a more pleasant regime possible. By Sunday, the broader review returns: what has been done, and what will need to be done during the coming week. Z rises again, creating a strong contrast.



Imagine playing a game without trying to win. Z may fall. But if you check whether it is working, count the time, repeat moves intentionally, ask yourself questions, compare it with another experience, try to suppress or alter thoughts, or generate a next step/thought, Z rises again.

The goal is not to erase the instrumental regime.



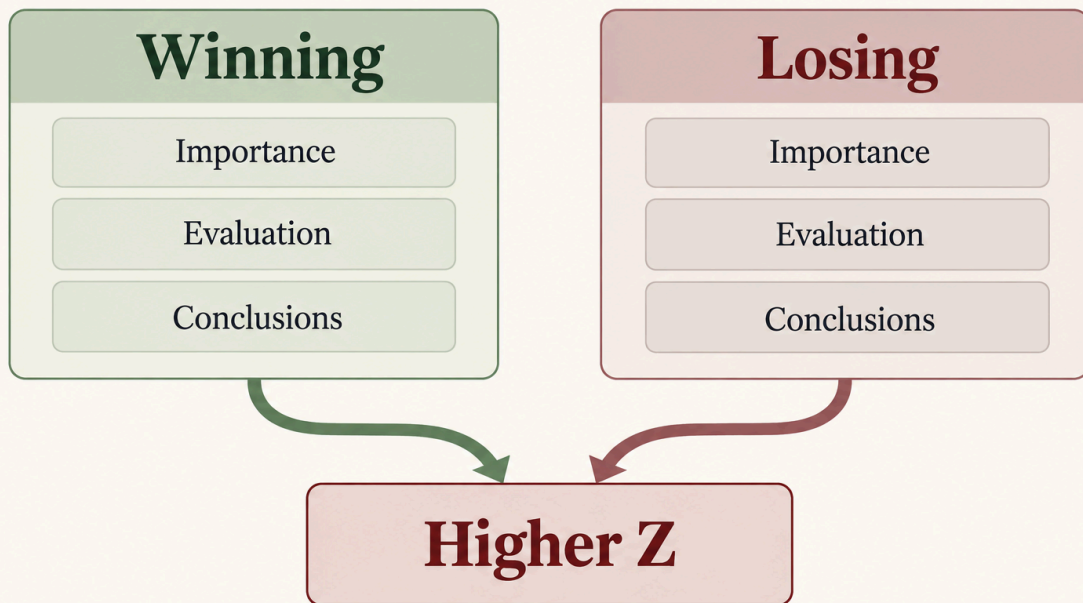
The aim is not to eliminate instrumental functioning, but to restore flexible access to a non-instrumental regime. However, for a first transition, a significant drop of Z is required.

Any thought that departs from “We will see later” or “Nothing needs to be optimized here” and any image that departs from a scene without action, may increase Z. As Z rises, thoughts become increasingly evaluative: The current instrumental regime may therefore make non-instrumental actions feel unnatural.

Memories and most mental images are a source of Z because they recruit evaluation. In a hypothetical future where there were no longer practical demands to meet, one might ask whether reducing involuntary visual recollection, while preserving skills and knowledge, could lower this evaluative load. This is a conceptual question, not yet an argument for erasing memories.

Winning vs. Losing

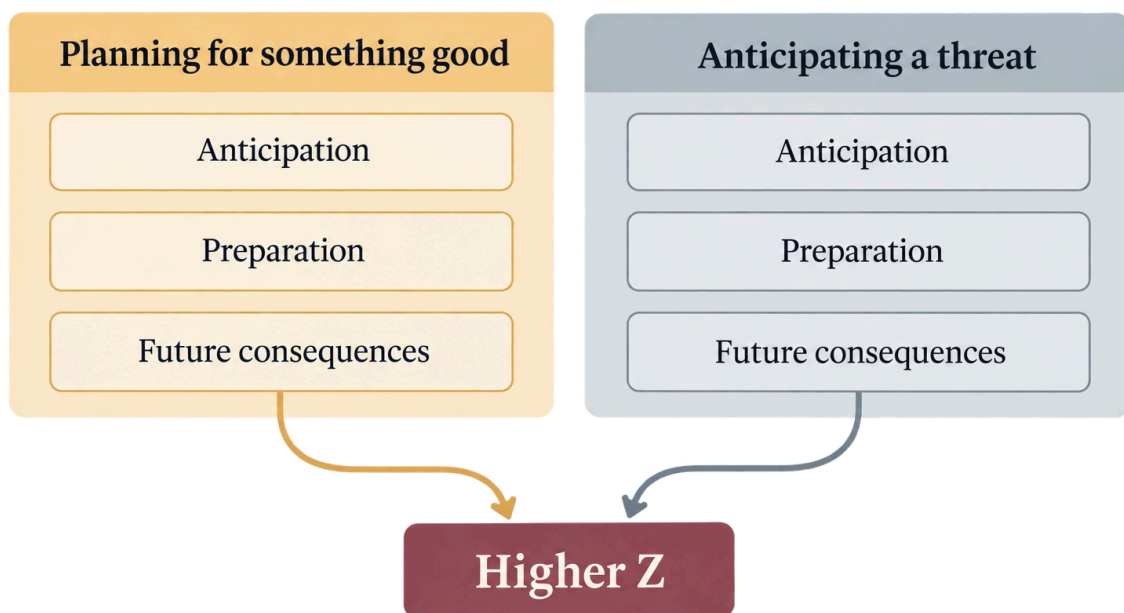
Different feeling, similar evaluative load.



Winning at a game or a contest and losing feel different, but both can raise Z through importance, evaluation, and conclusions.

Positive and negative anticipation

Different feeling, similar future-oriented load



Planning for a positive event and anticipating a threat both raise Z.

Objects

Seeing objects primarily through their functions increases Z. When we enter a room, we notice equipment, even equipment made for enjoyment, and immediately assign it a use. The felt seriousness of the scene increases, and so does Z.

Pause Before Utility: After picking up an object, let it remain in your hand briefly before using it.

Object as companion: Pick an item and keep it as if it is a companion.

Several Objects Together: Briefly notice several objects together before one becomes the focus.

The Present Moment

The idea that the present moment is all that exists, and therefore must be fully attended to, is deeply embedded in our culture. But treating the present as important may itself increase Z. *One Among Many* offers a different stance: instead of treating the current event as the only moment that counts, it is understood as one insignificant moment among many. A mouse click is simply one click among others. Any situation can be treated in the same way.

This is closer to a child's stance. If an adult returned to childhood to relive a school break, they might not recover the feeling if they tried to "live the present." The child experiences each break as ordinary, preceded by countless other breaks. It is disposable, unexceptional, and not worth extracting anything from.

This lack of importance lowers Z.

Colors

Colors are rapidly integrated into object recognition and functional interpretation, helping identify what things are and what to do with them.

Let the Colors Stand Out: Briefly let the colors in the scene stand out without becoming signals for action.

Importance

Importance must be justified for monitoring to become active. Objects are therefore categorized primarily according to their value. Monitoring remains active when importance, value, or rarity is justified. Gold, for instance, is rare because its supply is limited, precious because it is useful for particular purposes, and expensive because its market price is high. Perceiving gold as precious for these reasons therefore reinforces Z.

Sometimes, notice an useless or ordinary detail and artificially increase its ranking. For example, look at a broken pen, and label it as "important". Let the importance fade away normally immediately.

Preferences

Having a preferred time, place, or destination can lead to planning around it. Letting go of this is not easy, because it suggests that the flat, uninteresting places may not be so incompatible with joy compared with the place that feels wonderful.

But thinking, “*It will be great there,*” increases Z by increasing anticipation, comparison, and the search for evidence. There are no specific exercises for this, so one may simply try to progressively stop this behavior.

Cinema, Series, News, books and YouTube.

Films and series constantly call for what comes next: unanswered questions and narrative continuation. News and YouTube use a similar mechanism through clickbait and the promise of further information. In both cases, Z rises.

Much of this content is designed for a high-Z audience. It offers rewards suited to an evaluative regime, but does not support joy. The possible exceptions are slightly absurd or imperfect cartoons, music videos and tableau-like films in which each scene can stand on its own, often older adventure films.

When Z is already high, or begins rising again, there is a stronger impulse to search for this continuation-driven content. Sunday evening is a familiar example: the desire to watch, search, and find out what happens next often returns as the coming week becomes salient.

One can try:

Meaning Left Open: Briefly let something be understood only partway, good for both videos and books,

Neutral Liking: Briefly watch a character without deciding whether you like or dislike them.

Shapes First: Briefly notice the colors, shapes, and movement before the story becomes important.

Background Character: For a brief moment, let a background character seem as important as the main character

Imagination

We naturally think of imagination in positive terms. This form is highly visible: we can consciously reflect on possible scenarios for as long as we wish. Yet imagination, like checking, also operates continuously. Is it really necessary to imagine possibilities involving the next street we might take?

At times, you can refrain from extending your imagination by leaving unimagined what might be happening behind a door, beyond a window, or on the other side of an obstacle.

Time and Priority

In adult life, time is treated as a foundation of maturity and seriousness. Being late is considered a major fault, so the clock often remains active in the background of the mind.

Interestingly, in secondary school the opposite can sometimes apply: checking the time during class may be seen as impolite because it signals boredom. Looking at the clock can therefore be mildly discouraged. This social rule may reduce Z by making time-monitoring less available.

Nothing First: For a brief moment, nothing needs to become the first priority.

Nothing Needs to Happen Next: For a brief moment, nothing needs to happen next.

Humour

Although humour may seem opposed to Z, it often is not. Most humorous content revolves around politics, everyday problems, or social status, all of which recruit next-action pressure. Even absurd humour is not necessarily low-Z: it usually requires following a narrative and taking its setup seriously before the punchline arrives.

Humour can still be pleasant in a high-Z regime, and there is nothing wrong with that. But it is a form of pleasure that moves experience away from joy.

Sacralization

Sacralization is close to the idea of the “present moment”: when something stands out as special, important, or meaningful, Z rises. It does not need to have monetary value. A book on a table may be sacralized because it represents knowledge; even a bin may be sacralized because it represents ecology.

One possible exercise is to mentally equalize an object’s importance with what surrounds it. The same can apply to a route: briefly equalizing possible directions, or to software options, browser tabs, and icons.

Another way to reduce the “sacred” quality of perception is:

What Appears, Appears: look at or open something. There is nothing you need to feel. What appears, simply appears.

Searching for Salience.

In everyday life, Z can rise quickly. One process that may maintain it is the search for salience, including a direct attempt to find joy. This can involve repeatedly checking whether something is “there,” but also trying to provoke it visually, for example by looking at the sun or at nature because it is supposed to be beautiful.

Searching for salience raises Z because it quickly becomes a small investigation: *Is this vivid enough? Is it working? Should I look longer or somewhere else?*

In a Z high regime, it is difficult, but one could try looking at an ordinary detail, without verifying if something happened. It cuts pleasure, and that is the point.

Checking

“It is time to check” is Z high. The clearest example occurs when we lock the front door. We often go back to make sure that it is “properly locked.”. What is less obvious is that the same behavior occurs constantly. Suppose I put a glass on a table. It may seem that no checking has taken place, but it was simply so fast that it never entered conscious awareness. The automatic checks include: “Is this really a sensible place to put the glass?” or “Is it too close to the edge?” All of this happens within milliseconds.

At times, moving an object, moving toward something, looking at something without verifying, can lower Z, provided that it does not become a method, which would add verification to the non-verification itself.

The Action Is Enough: Briefly let one small action be enough.

Open questions

In the media, especially the news, a process maintains monitoring: questions left open through clickbait. News headlines often avoid answering the subject directly. For example: “LIVE. White House meeting: the president will speak after meeting with party leaders.” Reading this immediately raises questions such as “Why?”, “When?”, and “With whom?”, because the relevant information has been carefully withheld from the headline. Most narrative media also continuously let questions open, which is also called suspense. In both cases, Z is increased.

Sometimes, read a news title and don’t treat it as a question that needs an answer.

Question Without Answer: Think of a simple question. Do not search for an answer. Let the question fade.

Next Action

There is usually a next action. Each day becomes an uninterrupted sequence of small tasks.

Before the Next Action: Briefly let the next action remain undecided. Then continue normally.

Social Life

Apart from local, purposeless playground games, social life tends to involve a considerable amount of monitoring. Consider a few simple and common situations: waiting for someone, having an appointment, searching for arguments, trying to be

relevant or funny, attempting to project a particular image through good posture, talking about oneself, which forces a return to main-character thinking, or anticipating and imagining other people's reactions in order to prepare a better response.

In a light conversation context, you can say something "as if it is complete enough."

Recognition or Approval: Generate a feeling of recognition or approval.

Normally, perceiving a character rapidly recruits evaluation, interpretation, or preparation for a social response. This exercise briefly generates a simple feeling of recognition or approval, allowing it to exist without needing to analyze or act on it.

Books

Open a book at any page, and read some lines in an unordered fashion. If you happen to not understand the story, let the meaning open, instead of trying to understand it.

Comparison

Normally, the environment rapidly recruits a preferred direction, preparing movement toward one option rather than another.

For a brief moment, neither side of the street seems preferable.

Equal Importance: For a brief moment, notice nearby objects equally. There is no need to choose which one deserves more attention.

Valuing Something, Including Pleasure

When we do something that interests us, we attend to what matters in that situation. Comparison becomes highly active, and each relevant detail acquires importance. Think of a song or a patch of sunlight that you try to hold on to, only for the beginnings of joy to collapse thirty seconds later instead of growing.

Two things matter here: avoid assigning special value to the state, and sometimes even interrupt it deliberately, for example by stopping a song just as you begin to enjoy it.

Thoughts such as "This has to continue" increase perceived value and evaluation, causing the peak to collapse rather than sustaining it.

Briefly see a video you like as simply an MP4 file.

Briefly notice one visual detail that is irrelevant to what you are doing.

Those 2 exercises will collapse joy, which is something that must be tolerated.

As a Conclusion: Within a Video Game (2-3 minutes)

Choose a video game, decrease its seriousness

- remove or ignore score
- don't try to win
- do suspension moves, for example changing direction for no reason, or do a micro-mouvement, without checking
- add any brief exercise you want, keep them spaced and the session short

Florian Morin proposes that joy is gated by evaluative monitoring: joy does not simply fade, it becomes inaccessible when monitoring and optimization remain active.

References

Morin, F. (2026). A Regime Theory of Joy: The Ease Regime as a Permissive Control Configuration. SSRN. <http://dx.doi.org/10.2139/ssrn.6711318>

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